

West Nile Virus — What you need to know

A mosquito-borne virus most active in Arizona during late summer and fall

West Nile virus is spread by mosquitoes that have fed on infected birds. Most people who get infected (about 80%) have no symptoms at all. About 1 in 5 develop a flu-like illness called West Nile fever. About 1 in 150 develops a serious illness affecting the brain or spinal cord (West Nile neuroinvasive disease).

Symptoms

- Fever and chills
- Headache and body aches
- Tiredness and weakness
- Joint pains
- Nausea or vomiting
- A fine red rash on the chest, stomach, and back (sometimes)
- Severe: stiff neck, confusion, tremors, weakness on one side, seizures

What you should do

1. Rest and drink plenty of fluids. There is no specific antiviral medication for West Nile virus; treatment is supportive.
2. Take over-the-counter pain and fever medications as needed.
3. Watch for severe symptoms — stiff neck, confusion, weakness on one side of the body. Go to the ER right away if these develop.
4. Drain standing water around your home where mosquitoes breed (flowerpot saucers, gutters, pool covers, buckets).
5. Use EPA-registered insect repellent containing DEET, picaridin, or oil of lemon eucalyptus during dawn and dusk.

If a horse on your property was diagnosed first

West Nile virus is **not directly contagious from horses to humans** — both species get the virus from mosquito bites. But a confirmed equine West Nile case means infected mosquitoes are active in your area, and humans on the property are at risk. Take mosquito protection seriously: drain standing water, use repellent, avoid being outdoors at dawn and dusk.

Recovery

Most people with West Nile fever recover fully within a few weeks, though tiredness and weakness can last months. People who develop the neuroinvasive form may have long-lasting weakness, memory problems, or seizures. People over 60 and those with weakened immune systems are at higher risk.

Go to the emergency room if you have:

- Severe headache with stiff neck
- Confusion or unusual sleepiness
- Weakness on one side of the body or trouble walking
- Seizure
- Tremors or muscle twitching with fever

More information

- Arizona Department of Health Services Vector-borne Disease Program: 602-364-4562
- CDC West Nile Virus page: [cdc.gov/westnile](https://www.cdc.gov/westnile)
- Maricopa County Vector Control: 602-506-0700

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